

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Hospitality and Tourism English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For hotel managers, front-desk teams, guest-relations staff, event coordinators, restaurant managers, tour operators, revenue managers, and destination-service professionals.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

ADR

Average daily rate: room revenue divided by rooms sold for the stated period.

attrition

An agreed reduction in booked event rooms or attendance, sometimes subject to charges.

AV requirement

An audio or visual equipment need for an event, such as microphones or projection.

BEO

Banquet event order: a document specifying arrangements and responsibilities for an event.

brand voice

The recognizable style and tone a brand uses in communication.

check-in

The process of registering an arrival; also a short meeting to review progress.

compensation

Payment or another remedy; in employment, the pay and benefits provided for work.

compression night

A hotel-market period of strong demand and limited room availability.

cultural expectation

An expectation shaped by experience and social context; it should not be assumed from nationality alone.

force majeure

A contractual provision addressing specified events beyond a party's control; effects depend on the wording and law.

guest complaint

A guest's expression of dissatisfaction with a hospitality service.

guest profile

Relevant recorded preferences and service information about a guest, handled under applicable privacy rules.

itinerary

A planned sequence of travel activities, locations, and times.

local operator

A provider responsible for delivering travel or tour services in a destination.

occupancy

The proportion of available rooms occupied or sold during a stated period.

online review

Public feedback posted on a digital platform about a product or experience.

out of order

A room or item unavailable for normal use because of a problem or required work.

overbooking

Accepting more reservations than the available capacity based on expected cancellations or no-shows.

preventive maintenance

Planned work intended to reduce failures and maintain equipment condition.

rate parity

An arrangement concerning consistency of hotel rates across specified distribution channels.

recovery gesture

An authorized service action intended to help address a disappointing guest experience.

RevPAR

Revenue per available room: room revenue divided by available rooms for the stated period.

room inventory

The rooms available for sale or assignment under the property's current status definitions.

room status

A room's recorded availability or service condition, such as occupied or out of order.

run of show

A timed sequence of an event's activities and responsibilities.

service recovery

Actions taken to address a service failure and restore the customer's experience.

service standard

A stated expectation for how a service should be delivered.

turnover

Preparing a room for the next guest; in staffing, the rate of people leaving an organization.

upgrade

A move to a higher service category, room type, or product capability.

waiver

A documented relinquishment or exception concerning a right or requirement, subject to applicable terms and law.

walk

In hospitality, relocating a guest to another property when the booked accommodation cannot be supplied.

yield management

Adjusting price and availability to manage revenue from limited, time-sensitive capacity.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Guest Arrival and Front-Desk Escalation

A guest arrives before the room is ready after receiving an unclear confirmation message. The desk has a luggage-storage option but no verified room-ready time.

I'm sorry the message was unclear. Your room is not ready yet. We can store your luggage while I check the status, and I'll give you an update as soon as I have a confirmed time.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

02 | Complaint Handling and Online Reviews

A draft response to an online review argues with the guest and includes booking details. The team needs a courteous public reply.

Thank you for sharing your experience. We're sorry the visit did not meet expectations. Please contact our service team through the private channel so we can review the details with you.

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

03 | Reservations, Overbooking, and Walks

A booking issue means the reserved room type is unavailable. Staff have two alternatives within their approved service process.

The reserved room type is unavailable, and I'm sorry for the inconvenience. Let me explain the two available options, including any differences in facilities or cost, so you can choose what works for you.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

04 | Revenue Management and Pricing

A hotel reports a higher average daily rate but lower occupancy. A manager assumes every revenue measure must have improved.

The average rate and occupancy moved in different directions. We need to look at revenue per available room as well before describing the overall room-revenue performance.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

05 | Housekeeping, Maintenance, and Turnover

Housekeeping marks a room cleaned, but maintenance has an open repair request. Reception asks whether it can be assigned.

Cleaning is complete, but the maintenance request is still open. Please confirm the room's approved status with the responsible team before telling reception that it is available.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

06 | Events, Banquets, and Run of Show

An event schedule lists "sound check" without a time, room, or responsible contact. The venue and organizer assume the other will arrange it.

Could we confirm the sound-check time, location, and contact person? I'll add those details to the run of show so the venue and organizer share the same plan.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

07 | Tour Operations and Traveler Safety

Heavy weather may affect an excursion. The operator has not confirmed whether it will proceed. Guests ask if the original itinerary is certain.

The operator is reviewing the conditions, so the itinerary is not yet confirmed. I'll share the next official update and explain any approved alternatives when they are available.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

08 | Cultural Expectations and Service Style

A guest declines an offered service. A colleague assumes the reason is the guest's nationality.

Let's ask about the guest's preference rather than assume the reason. Would you prefer a different arrangement, or would you like us to explain the available options?

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.